

Would you marry a girl who has three breasts? asked May Kasahara. Reading Murakami is a weird feeling but somehow I like his work. Enough reading for today. It's midnight and I have a running fever, but my reading ritual is as important as my health. I am drowning in my bed, tightly tucked in my blanket. The rain is pouring outside. My eyes are heavy and I am burning and sweating. I place my mobile phone beside my head. "I should use my tab for the reading" I thought as my eyes are straining. My phone buzzes twice. I know right away that someone is messaging me. I thought of leaving it for the next morning but What if someone needs me. I quickly grab my phone and check the message. It's from Megha, a girl I knew from my college. She is asking me how life is treating me right now. That's an odd question to ask at this midnight hour, when I have a temperature. A sudden burst of her memories stirs my mind. It reminds me of her grey t-shirt and her big dark eyes. I have a vision of her saying my name. I see her sitting in a cafe, waiting for me with an empty cup of coffee. I see her. She sees me and she smiles. Why is this happening to me? Six months back I decided not to talk to her. What was the reason? I am not quite sure. I just decided one night when I was in Mumbai feeling tired from work. I was about to sleep and was making plans for the next day that I will write my pages from four in the morning to eight. That midnight when she messaged me. We talked about books and spirituality. I remember it was a rather tiring experience to talk about things you already know. It doesn't make sense. I remembered how I hurt my fingers with all the texting and it was 2am when I forcefully concluded the chat. I told her that I needed to sleep, as I needed to write my morning pages and then the office. Those miserable eight hours. A tinge of fear ran through my spine. Hey, how are you? Where have you been? message after message my phone continuously vibrates, it makes me uneasy. I reluctantly reply thinking I would tell her not to message me again. Last time we talked I was in Mumbai, working a nine to five job and was trying to write in the meantime and a lot happened. I just blurted out everything that's happened to me. She was reacting as she should, with all the hmm's and oh's. She would ask a question and I would reply to her remembering all the shit I was doing over the past six months. "What happened, it's been six months and you never ever thought of messaging me," she asks. Oh, that is a tough question to answer, well the real answer is that I didn't wanted to talk to you. I am a writer and I need solitude. Most artists need solitude to create their piece of work. So I put a limit on people, whom I talk to. There are so few people in my life whom I talk about my work, casual meet ups, and few friends I travel with. And anyone other than them is just an interruption. I care for people. I don't want them to feel hurt. So I lie. Whenever someone asks me why I didn't call them or messaged them in a long time. I just told them that I was depressed and I didn't feel like talking to anybody. They just accept it. Depression is something that people don't touch. So their response is always like. "Call me if you need me". And they always say in the end that " let's catch up when you feel like" and I reply with a single word. 'Sure' . I sent all this to Megha and with her hmm's and oh's I thought the conversation was about to end. An image flashes in my mind that she is grabbing her head, and cursing herself for messaging me. The mobile phone vibrates with the message of her saying. "Can I call you?" What is this? My body sweats. I told her that I have a fever and speaking will make me sicker. I sigh as she replies. "Oh, maybe another time". "Yeah", I said. "another time". Then she asks me to call her, message her, anytime I want to. And she told me that depression fades away when you talk about it with someone. "You would do that for me". I ask her. "you want to take my loathsome past experiences and the ones that will be coming in the future". "Yeah! Anytime you want. Anything you want." She says. "Well thank you". I reply. "no one really was available for me in my twenty four years of experience. I am used to solving my problem all by myself and I despise throwing my baggage on to people just to relieve my conscience. I am not like that. But you asked me, I am grateful for that. Really thank you." "Well bring it on, all the shit you have in your life. I am there for you". She texts furiously, reflecting excitement, then she dared to ask me that tomorrow is her calligraphy class and if I wanted to meet her. The caret blinked on the screen as if poking me to type something. What is happening to me? My heart races. If I meet her I need to act depressed or what if it becomes a date and I end

up kissing her. Do I really want her in my life, right now? Relationships are beautiful but it demands a lot. It will surely divide my attention and I am writing a novel and it will just not be right to include any girl right now. Oh god. Do I like her?. I don't think so. I decided a long time ago that I am not interested in her. All we talk about is books, and books are not the reason to be in a relationship. I want a girl unrelated to what I do. Maybe a doctor. I really like a doctor for me. My anxiety about my health created this fascination of being with a doctor. She would come tired from her shift. She will be smelling of her rose perfume mixed with the smell of the hospital which will arouse me for some reason, and by the time she will be home, I have had finished my writing session and will embark on making an espresso for her and me. She will reluctantly accept the espresso and she would curse me that this is bad for our health, and we will take it sip by sip. I will hold her and help her in relieving the pressure of her work as a god, that she is in the hospital, and then we will cook together sharing a single beer. "What happened?" My mobile phone vibrates with her text. I snap out of my imagination. I quickly thought of a reply and told her that. I am writing a short story collection on a contract basis and I need a few days alone. I told her three days is all I need. Until then I won't be able to message or call her. After that we can meet. She agreed to the contract. And I sigh. I need time to think about her. If I need her in my life or not. I conclude the chat and place my phone beside me. I am about to sleep when a vision of me making passionate love with megha ran through my mind, we both are breathless. I squeeze my eyes to erase that image. The last of the drops hit the night puddles and dogs are hounding saving their piece of land. I fell asleep.

Next morning as I sip my coffee that I made in exploring the memories of megha. I am hating her right now. My life was good. I would say better. Writing, Reading, and watching films. My favorite routine. Just living in the proper illusion. Building an amazing story. Talking about truth. Escaping reality, so that I can create something worthwhile. But now I am thinking about you. What were you thinking? Why did you message me? It's been six months. I almost forgot about you. Now your memories are flashing in front of my eyes, racing my heart. Making my groin tickle. Do I really need you? Males are functioned to be attracted to women. It is just God's full proof plan, that wants us to reproduce and create babies. I don't know the reason. But I am sure he wants us to reproduce and we call it love. Call it whatever you want. But in the end it's all about reproduction and babies. and when you are done with it, the downfall begins and I don't need either of it. Ah! My head is hurting and it's just the morning. I find myself with a cold cup of coffee in the middle of the semi dark kitchen. I see a pigeon trying to look through the window. I drain my coffee in the sink and pace towards my room. I sit on my wooden stool. I should write something. I pick up my fountain pen. I flip through my notebook. My pen marks on the paper, the sentence is about to begin and characters are getting alive in my head. I write my first word. A passing image of me kissing megha's long elegant neck as I explore her body with my hand, struck in my mind like a brisk wind. I find my characters in my mind glaring at me. Their look was saying that they know that their character arc will be incomplete for a while as I have to solve this sudden blunder. Oh god, I need to fix this. What's happening to me?

My phone rings. It's rather loud and somehow it is making me nervous. Why is that? I am scared to find out. What if Megha is trying to call me. What if she wants to meet me? I know her dominance over things she wants to do and anyway I am more of a submissive guy who agrees with a girl to a point of discomfort. I was afraid to pick my phone up. I squint my eyes and look at the screen. It's not megha. I didn't knew that I was out of breath. now that I am relaxed. I pick up the call. It was Anuj. He is a traveler who wants to be a vlogger and he was working a part time job in a cafe in the outskirts of Himachal. He travels when time allows him to. He asks me how I am doing. If I have any leads for a publisher.

"Nope!" I say. " One can only try, lets see when it happens" . Then I turned the conversation around and used my recent blunders with megha as a topic to talk about, and he was excited for me. He told me not to waste

this opportunity to get the girl. Its hard to find someone caring for people like us who live for freedom and on top of that she understand me and I should grab the opportunity when I can, and fucking now and then is a cherry on the top. It will be perfect. He is making sense, but I need to think rationally. She is an individual and she also has needs. And I can not accept her just for some selfish reasons. "Hello! Hello! Can you hear me?" He tries to connect. "Yeah! Yes. I am here." I say. "So what will you do!" He inquires. "Well I am meeting you there.tomorrow". "Bullshit!" He shower the sounds of excitement . "Really i want to meet you. Let's talk about shit. Let's solve it together. I need to know what I should do about megha."

"There's nothing to do. Just date her and complement her, then fuck her brains out. That's it. Why are you thinking so much? It's not rocket science. It's just a leap of faith. You understand." "Do you want me there or not?" I oblige. "Sure,sure, when are you leaving?" "Today at five pm". "Were you planning for it?" He asks "No, I just decided. Mountains are the best place to think, I guess. Above that I want your crazy travel romance stories. I need to write about something wonderful".

He laughs, I laugh too . "Sure man! Come! Let's meet. You know the place." "Yes!" I say. "Alright then! Bye. I need to attend to some guests." "Cool! Bye" I say. With a beep the call cuts and the silence takes over the room. Sunlight is trying hard to enter the room but the curtains are blocking it, which are glowing like a rectangular light source. I pack my stuff. I am sweating. I am relieved that megha is not on my mind. All the picturesque environments I'm going to visit are flashing in my mind. All the foreigners and their stories. It just fills me with joy. Be in the mountains. Talking to people. Living in a different culture. Fall in love with a girl, you are never going to see again. The sun bath in the summer time with chilly glacier wind breaking my cheeks apart. Making it red. As if I am blushing. Just lying there. Looking at the blank sky. No traffic. Hear people talking in the language unknown to my mind. It's just magnificent. It's three thirty in the afternoon and I board the metro. It's semi full. Lot's of space to move freely to contemplate, as I stand on the exit gate looking over to the vastness of an overexposed city. I sense a thread. A shimmering thread tether to my heart and is reaching far away to the point my eyes can see. It pulls hard, eliciting a tingle in my heart. I am experiencing loss and sadness. The shimmering thread is trying hard to detach itself from me. I try to detach myself from it but the thread is not physical in nature. I thought that it was just an undecided metaphor of my disillusioned yet aware mind. I ignore it. But the tingling persists, which make me think of megha. She seems more beautiful, more elegant, as I gaze into her eyes. Her grey t-shirt is well fitted. Why does it happen that I imagine myself ugly, Wearing a knicker and an olive green cheap robe With an unattended beard and a balding head . I think the contrast makes her more beautiful. I touch my metro card on the sensors. The small gates allows me to pass. I look for gate number eight for the exit. My eyes caught the glimpse of some beautiful girls. I enjoy looking at them. The Visual ads up to my memory bank, which helps me in my distinct description for my characters. I took the exit and made my way towards the bus stand, my eyes are scanning everywhere for a cigarette shop. The time was 4:50PM, and I needed to find the bus quickly. After hesitating and wandering around a bit, dodging slow, old, and tired people, I approached the security checkpoint. I placed my magenta handbag and backpack on the scanning machine for inspection. Once through the security check, I finally find my way to the bus. With a sense of relief, I settled down in my window seat, which was 34A. I silently hope that no one would occupy the seat next to me.

Traveling with friends can enhance the journey and make the time pass more easily. However, at that moment, I find myself sitting alone, with idle hands and a craving for dopamine. The urge to smoke arise within me, but I know I have to wait until the bus stop . I put on my earphone. It is getting dark really fast. The sun is fading away, the whole bus is gleaming with the last of the sun's gradient. I had recently discovered a song called "Suzume- theme song". I guess suzume is a movie. The music is soothing; every beat draw a cinematic experience around me. I thought of megha. The shimmering thread reappears. It looks more beautiful,

straight out of a rainbow. It is attach to my chest and the thickness seems to have increased. If I have observed it correctly. It is not attached to my skin, when I pull it, it just extends off my chest. It is not hurting. It is not physical in nature. It changes color according to how I feel. The thread vibrates, followed by my heart. It feels weirdly good. This is the first time my heart has vibrated. I had heard about it from my long lost friends, who told me that in love the heart vibrates, sometimes. And I Insulted them because the word "love" is something I find disturbing. When I love a woman, I live with her, I make love with her and then I start to find things I don't like about her, and the love fades away. Then I wait for her to make one mistake. I hope she would cheat on me with another man. So, that she can be happy. and I can leave her peacefully. Is love temporary? Or if I stay true to my girl and I live with her, care for her my whole life even if I don't love her. And we have a kid and I will love him unconditionally. I don't have one but I know I will love her or him to death. Then the definition of love is totally different. The only conclusion that I draw despite that I hate to draw conclusions, because conclusions about anything limits you from your understanding of nature and life itself. But I draw the conclusion that love is different for different relationships. With a girl I like. With my sister. With my relatives. With a tree. With a cloud. With a god. It is all a different sheer intensity of love. God works in a mysterious way. He always confuses our species with his contradictions which limits us to discover something magnificent beyond our five senses. Anyway, I look outside as I thought about megha again. What kind of love is it I have for you, I thought. The thread reappears with a pulsating nature, the thick shimmering thread reaches towards the sky. It is spilling colors as if excited about something. I try to grab it, but my hands are passing through it. I look around to see if people are aware of my shimmering thread. Dull faces of theirs show no interest. Maybe my disillusioned mind created this illusion. The music swells to be more romantic, the melody is just melting every cell in my body. Suzume. I should watch it. I recalled the time when I was on a date with megha. We had a coffee where we talked about a girl that was in our class. I told her that the girl was so beautiful that the first thought of me and my fellow attendees of this beauty was of rejection. She was so beautiful that we thought of not trying to impress her at all. She was like a queen and we were like laborers. She laughed, hiding her pain that I don't find her attractive enough. I realized I made a mistake. Why did I have to talk about beauty that was not her. Usually a date is all about making her feel special. I told her that it was just for the beginning. "What do you mean?" she sipped her coffee, and crossed her hands, which pushed her breasts closer, I tried not to look. I told her: "If one is ugly or beautiful it doesn't matter. Because when our eyes are used to that person, the ugly one is not ugly anymore and a beauty is not beautiful anymore. They will be just average looking people because our eyes are used to them. How they are and how they behave or if they care about other people, that's all that matters and I tell you that she may be beautiful but she was a bitch, sorry for the foul word but I needed to tell you". She spread her arms apart, took a sip of her coffee, before gently placing her hand on the table, all the while attempting to conceal her burgeoning excitement. This Was my moment to compliment her and turn this conversation in my favor. I lowered my voice as I reached for her hand, it halted near her pointed nails. I told her that "the girl we are talking about is a bitch and you are far better than her, I should not compare but I have to. I tell you that you are caring. Your whole being radiates positivity. And I find your eyes particularly captivating. Our body weakens as we grow old and eyes are the reason that things will work out for good because they will be the same all over our life and I really like to be lost in them". A rosy blush appeared on her cheek. Her left hand clutched on her side and the right hand pressed against her lap. With a smile on her face she cast her gaze down. I sipped my coffee and was hoping to get a smoke. But she doesn't like smokers.

I snap out of my imagination. The bus rattles on an uneven road. I decide to pause the music as it is clouding my judgment for megha and I won't be able to think rationally. She doesn't like smokers, since I smoke, she will scream when she gets to know it. And I remembered a particular incident when a guy was getting personal as he was awkwardly flirting with her. She was feeling uneasy and she screamed at him. Saying normal words like - get out, don't show your face again, but the way she was screaming those simple words

with a sharp constant loud voice. The pitch was on the lower spectrum but was seeping through every pore of my body. I was afraid of it and it was an instant turnoff for me. I fear screams and violence and her scream was like a sharp pain that sometimes happens in your chest area when you think you are going to have a heart attack. I noticed the guy's hands were shaking in fear. Mine as well. I was just a few screams away from shitting my pants.

The bus stops as the conductor screams to wake us up. "The stop is here, go get some refreshment and be back in fifteen minutes. We are running late". They had to say this to create the urgency for 40-50 people to hurry so that they don't take long. I look at all the passengers shuffling outside, and few are waiting for their turns to get up. I step out. It's chilly. My breath is white. I look up. Orion was shining in the clear sky. I remember, one night we were on the phone and I was looking at the Orion constellation. She was talking about how someone made fun of her hair style. I interrupted her and asked her to look up at the sky. She was in her bed and I prompted her to look outside. She must have walked silently. She passed her parents room and very gently opened her main gate, which creaked anyway. Her eyes squinted, she looked back. She was outside wearing a nightgown. She once told me that she doesn't wear a bra when she sleeps. She told me all about it. She told me about their types, and how uncomfortable it feels while she wears it and when she finally get the chance to remove it, she removes it, as it makes her feel free. She looked up at the sky, and I was explaining to her the pattern of the orion, and where to look for it. But she couldn't find it. Such a disappointment.

The loud bus horn startle me, and I suddenly crave a smoke. I buy three Marlboro Lights and lit one up, but it made me feel uneasy. The smoke mixed with my breath, creating a confusing sensation, as if my breath turned into a never-ending white winter exhale. In frustration, I toss the cigarette and crush it with my foot. Soon after, the bus conductor call us with a whistle. It reignited the memories of my school days. But I don't want to think about that. I slide down on my seat. The engine roars, the bus starts to shake. Weird poor kids were staring at our windows. I put my head on the glass which feels cold. A chill ran down my spine, and I feel a wave of fatigue wash over me. Thoughts of Megha occupy my mind. In the midst of my drowsiness, the shimmering thread reappear before me. I found myself fixating on the cars passing by, my eyes growing heavy with each blink. Eventually, sleep takes over me, and I drift into the slumber.

The bus conductor screams, "we are about to be there". I look around. Everyone is drowsy and their hands are trying to hold a grip to wake up. I look outside. The deep trench makes me want to puke. I look up to see the mountains that are adorn with small houses lit with white and yellowish fluorescent lights. It looks like the vast sky somehow reflecting on the surface. As the bus drifts on a sharp turn we get the glimpse of far mountain ranges with more lit houses. It looks so pleasing in the dark. The conductor cries again, "get ready". It's chilly outside. I unzip my bag, take out my red hoodie. I fit myself in it. I zip my bag. And I am ready. It's 4:30 am. I panic. The bus is supposed to reach at 6am. Why this early. It starts to rain outside. Oh my god. Why now? As we are going up to the mountain. The rain is getting louder. And I get to know that these clouds come down on their own. And a fear takes over me. What if one of the clouds burst right here on us? Why are they so much closer? And why is it that they are raining? Have you ever experienced a situation where it's raining and you can see the exact source from where it's happening? These are the things that are meant to be private. These things can force you to contemplate your existence. I can see the road. And the safety roller grill is visible ,but the deep trench was taken over by the grey clouds. It feels like a dream state. Am I dreaming? Is this real? I check my wallet. It is an old black waxed, torn edged, with old grocery slips hiding in there for eternity. And a thousand rupees note that I don't spend. I sigh. It's real and happening. Sometimes I feel like I am in a dream where reality feels different from it should be. So I check my wallet for a thousand rupees note. I had observed that in my dreams , my wallet is always empty. So if I am dreaming the wallet will be empty.

Phew, that is not the case for the moment the clouds are really raining before my eyes. It feels weird though. The bus halts at the bus station. I want to wait until all the people have gotten off the bus. It took them five minutes. However, the conductor gestures for me to get out. I hurriedly shuffle out, nodding at him as I inadvertently brushes against him while stepping out. The rain is not there. But the clouds are behaving eerily. I can see them behind me. They are taking over this mountain as if to trap me here. The back of the bus is not visible. I check my wallet again. The money is there then why is my heart racing. I look in front of me and find that the clouds are swirling around like a tumbleweed on a barren highway road. I check my wallet again. A thousand rupee note is there. I made a mistake waiting for the passengers to leave, all the cabs are gone. A few people and three monks are waiting. A driver approaches the monks, and asks them to come with him and they refuse as they want to walk all the way up. The driver says. "It's dangerous to walk in this weather, what if a thunder strikes on you." The monks consider it for a bit and stare at me. Oh man, I look in my wallet. Money is there. I move away. I see a driver sitting on a driver's side staring at nothingness. He is focused on a point in front of him, not looking at anything, but at the air, as if seeing a ghost. I move towards his car and knock on his window. He lowers it down and an unpleasant smell of alcohol just gusts out with its warmth. Oh! man he is drunk. I look around for a driver who is not drunk but the place is completely taken over by the grey clouds. I have no choice but to go with this drunk driver. "Hey! I want to go to the central market." "It's 5am, the shops are closed and the weather is also bad." He says. "I know, I have a hotel booked there." "Ok get in," he says. It starts to drizzle. Every small drop that hits my face feels like a bite of a small ant. "How much?" I ask. "300" he says. Done. I open the back door. I jump in with my backpack. And I put my trolley bag beside me. He jerks his car with a start. He laughs a bit and asks for forgiveness and he moves the car forward. The rain starts to pour hard. I look outside, the grey clouds are getting closer. It feels like only the car and the area visible by the beaming light of the car is the only living reality. All which can not be seen is being covered by the eerie grey clouds that are moving in spirals. I look down at the trench. It is being filled with the swirling grey clouds up to the brim. As we are moving up I see some eerie picturesque local houses with some abandoned vehicles that are slowly being claimed by green fungus. I notice that as we are moving up and steeper the grey clouds are getting thicker and thicker. I can see the clouds running in the beam light like a small kid shuffling carelessly on an empty road. The driver switches on the dim yellow light. The drops of rain are striking the window. The area turns bone chilling and cold. My breath is dense. The driver switches on the heater. The constant sound of rain pouring made me sleepy. I adjust my hoodie and slouch on the backseat and close my eyes.

"It's my first week of driving here. That's why you must be feeling that this ride is a little bumpy. Right. It will get better." He says.

I almost shit my pants. He is drunk and new with the mountains in this weather and probably this deep trench will devour us. Oh god. Save me. Instinctually I said. "One week that's enough, you are doing great." He seems proud. I compliment him so that he can feel confident. "You know I am not used to small cars. I have forty years of driving experience. But I usually drive Mercedes or Rolls Royce or any big car. They are smooth. They are fancy. The small cars are faulty." I am dreaming. I am dreaming. I take out my wallet and viciously look inside. The money is there. The driver looks at me through the rear view mirror. "Sir, why are you checking your wallet so often?" He asks.

"Ah! I just wanted to ask you if you accept online payment." "Oh! The wallet is empty. Don't worry sir, I was in a business where people never carry cash. Actually they had never seen cash for so long. They are used to pulling out their credit card with their first two fingers and throwing it upon people's faces with a look on their face that they don't care, just take the money and don't waste my time here." We both laugh. "That's my life," he says.

"Hmm. so do you accept online payment." I inquire

"Yes I do!" He seems concerned. He looks back as he confronts me. "That's why i..... "Look at the road, Mr." I say. He turns, realizing the bleak surrounding we are in. He continues. "That's why I told you the credit card story." "Well you could have just said, yes. I take online payment" He laughs and asks me to forgive him. "I was trying to keep the mood happy. It's my duty to make my passengers comfortable." he says.

He is drunk. It's understandable. I talk absurd shit when I am drunk. But I don't fucking dare to drive a car on a steep mountain. My fear grows on every turn. The heavy rain was taking its toll on us and we are moving so slow that It feels like few people are pushing the car from the back to take it to the destination.

Finally we have reached the central market. As I get out, the rain stops. I pay the amount using UPI. I go up to the bus stop in that area. I sit there and order a cup of tea from a tea stall adjacent to the bus stop. I pull out my remaining cigarette and smoke it as I sip my tea looking at the wondrous bluish mountains. I am sitting in a shed. The rain starts to pour, again. I look around and the clouds are all over the place. The sun is about to come. I record the silence, the beauty and the dominance of grey clouds and I post it on my instagram. Megha sees it. It's 6am and she is up. Oh god I hope she doesn't message me. I put my phone on the flight mode and decide not to share anything on social media without deciding our fate, megha, I don't want her to call me or message me.

I have to decide our fate. Do I really want you in my life? Megha. An image of her wet hair as she runs her hand through them comes in my mind and her wet tshirt, she is smiling at me. The shimmering thread appears and it is throbbing. I try to grab it. What, I am able to grab it now. How's that possible? it was not physical in nature. I thought it was just merely my imagination. I try to pull it. My heart aches. I follow it with my eyes. It is curving behind a grey cloud that is in the sky. It looks beautiful in the reddish blue glow.

My stomach roars for food. I order some boiled eggs as I wait for the rain to stop. The thread vanishes. An old man wearing a dhoti and an uneven grey patterned coat ran towards me hunching down with a full plate of boiled eggs. My mouth fills with water. I grab it and pay him in cash. I devour it completely and choke on the dryness of it. I grab my water bottle and sip some water as I don't want to lose the taste of it to go away. It relaxes my throat. I visit the hotel where my friend Anuj works. He takes care of the check in's and the check out's. I wonder if he sleeps at the reception.

I enter the building and a note read " reception is on the third floor" weird for a hotel to have a reception on the top of the building. Reception should be at the front with an English speaking charming woman sitting on it where she smiles every time someone comes and she makes sure that he or she stays at this hotel. But here everything is in reverse. I guess they want us to see the view first. I get up step by step. I pull out my wallet just to make sure I am not sleeping at the bus stop. The money is there. I returned my wallet to its place as I climb up mumbling the note written on the front. "The reception is on the third floor." I climb up to a long hall on the terrace with see through glass walled in on the wooden framing. I knock at the entrance. It is open. I push the door and I find my friend Anuj in the corner wrapped on his blanket. His nose is red. I kick him. "Hey asshole, wake up." He opens his eyes. "You!" He says. "Yeah. wake up." "just, few more hours, get in with me." He says with a lazy voice. "No thanks," I say. "Suit yourself," he says. "Fucker get up. I am a guest. Book me a room and I am hoping for some discount." He mumbles something as he turns in his blanket. I sigh. I sit down on the desk nearby on which lies premium tobacco and some ocb paper. Oh boy it was worth it. I roll myself two cigarettes. I lit one. It's smooth. Very smooth. I crave tea. But I have to wait. I am taking a lung full of smoke. My stomach clenches inside and twists. I need to go to the washroom as soon as possible. The bowel movement made me sweat. I tried to wake him up. But he sleeps like a dead man. I go down in a small

corridor with a few gates. I try to open them all. One is open. I enter the room, pass toward the washroom and pull down my pants and sit on the western. Oh boy, the seat is frosty. But it feels good, my whole being just feels light. I flame the top of my cigarette and take a long drag in and release it steadily. I allow it to come from my mouth and nose at the same time. It produces a calming effect on my mind. I hear someone entering the room, a female voice and a male one. I hear them muttering in himachali language. The room is booked for someone. If they caught me Anuj is going to lose his job and that fucker is dreaming in this cozy winter. I hear them kissing. He is definitely going to lose his job. I pull my pants up. Crush my rolled cigarette with my slipper. I decide to go out hauling. It's better to get caught while they are kissing. If they caught me while having sex. They will kill me out of embarrassment. I plunge out, haul towards the exit. We lock eyes. Their lips part ways quickly. I push the man and sprint towards the reception. I check my wallet. The money is there. I plunge into the reception hall. Anuj seems to be drooling. I put my luggage near his face. And I snuggle in the blanket with him to hide myself. I don't know when I have fallen asleep.

It is ten in the morning when Anuj wakes me up with a few kicks. I look at him with red eyes, as I wipe the oil off my face. It is cold but the sun is out. "I need to decide our fate. megha. You bitch I was living the best life. Writing, reading and watching films. You did me wrong. I really like your lips, though. They are puffy. Juicy. When you talk your upper lip tends to point upwards and the lower one is so puffy that a bite would burst it. I want it." I feel a tickle in my stomach. The shimmering thread reappears. I touch it and it vibrates. My heart fills with tingles. I need to sleep more. I snuggle in bed. After a while, Anuj returns to wake me up. I get up and ask him for a coffee and to roll a joint of cigarette for me, and book me a fucking room. I need to sleep more. He looks back agreeing with a dull face. His eyes are small. His face is darker than usual, and his mouth is nearly pouted. It feels like he is about to cry. Why? He has dark skin. Maybe he sits in the sun for long hours. What does he think about? He is not the kind of a guy who sits in the sun unaware of the effect it has on one's skin. He is bound to use skin products from his teenage days. He won't sit in the sun for that long unless he is going through something. What if his inner turmoil made him escape reality? He has found solace in his turmoils. What can be the problems? I take the exit to the big terrace and move around. The plants and flowers are arranged against the grill. The outside is mostly painted blue, perhaps an attempt to match it with the sky, but they have failed. It looks surreal though. The terrace is almost sky-blue with a dark blue painted grill and navy blue table and chairs. Silver shiny ashtrays sit on top of all the tables, and green plants line the borders. The floor reflects the clouds and sky. As I grab the grill, I see a few mountains, one after another, and beautiful houses up close that were built on those mountains. Our hotel shares the same mountain. The sky is fresh, and the mountains are green, bathed in sunlight. Grey clouds swirl at the peak, and I can see a few houses there. I wonder how one gets there. Anuj comes back with the cigarette and two cups of coffee, along with a room key. He arranges everything neatly on a table, and it's so organized that I don't bother to touch it, not wanting to disturb its beauty.

We settle down. I put my left leg on top of the right one as I smoke my rolled cigarette, while he sits there with a dead face, staring at the coffee. I sip my coffee, contemplating whether I should ask him if I will be paying for both the coffees, but it feels wrong to ask. I decide to ignore it.. "What's going on, brother? How's life treating you right now?" I ask. He starts crying, putting his left hand on his timid eyes. His whole being jerks as he makes sad sounds. He catches his breath in between and takes a puff of his rolled tobacco. I drag my chair near him to pat his back, trying to think of the perfect thing to say. What should one say in this situation? Maybe he wants to share everything that's been going on in his life. Should I ask him directly or sprinkle some motivational quotes on his turmoils? Quotes like, "The more hurdles in your life mean you are living lively. Everything is unpredictable, and that's good. You are not someone living a similar tiresome routine, seeing the same people again and again. You know it's boring. At least you get to experience those lustful women's, camping sex fantasies, and you are their way to experience it. Isn't it beautiful?" "That is true,



but I have not been able to create vlogs, and I am not able to travel much. I have exhausted every place here, and it's boring," he cries. Did I just tell him that? It never happened before. I never speak my thoughts. What should I say? My coffee is cold as usual. Why do I even bother drinking coffee? It always goes to waste. The rich aroma, hazelnut, original Arabian beans go down the sink every fucking day. Whenever I order or make myself coffee, the turmoils of any kind just appear from somewhere. I should avoid coffee.

Anuj snaps his fingers before my thoughtful eyes, and I look at him. He asks me to tell him something. What should he do? "Oh well! Don't ask me! Who am I to say anything? Your dreams, your shit, just man up," I thought. He stares at me, and I wonder if I said it out loud. No, he was waiting for the answer. I should say what he wants to hear. I tell him, "Listen, you want to be a vlogger, right? If you observe..." "Excuse me, who is at the reception?" interrupts a blue-eyed foreigner. She is wearing a cotton white T-shirt. She has a pale skin with a blush of rose allover and blond hair. She carries an olive green backpack bigger than her torso and seems out of breath. "Who is at the reception?" asks this amazing creation of God. She is out of breath, which is understandable after climbing four floors with such a gigantic backpack. She looks so perfect. Sometimes your brain captures some photos and portraits that it finds most wondrous. These kinds of memories captured by our brain are so vivid that you can't help but remember them till you die. It feels like I can look at her my whole life. Those blue eyes, those puffy pink lips. As she breathes, the straps of her bag squeeze her breasts together. Oh, she is my savior. I don't have to solve his problem anymore. He needs to attend to her. Thank God. I get up and approach her with Anuj, just to have a closer look. Her skin is so smooth and white. Anuj greets her with utmost gratitude, as if he is happy to be born to attend to her. She smiles. Oh boy, what a beauty. While Anuj attends to her, I smoke my rolled cigarette, admiring her beauty but occasionally stealing glances at her. I don't want to be like some pervert who stares like a crazy person; my eyes are gentle. I come to the conclusion that women wearing T-shirts are a turn-on for me, like Megha and her grey T-shirt, or the blue-eyed girl in the white T-shirt, among many other girls in my life. I find myself paying them more attention when they wear T-shirts. It's strange for a complex guy like me to be attracted to such a simple thing. Just to make sure that this is all real, I check my wallet, and the money is there. I scratch my head and swing my hand down. I haven't notice that the shimmering thread has appeared before me, and my hand hits it. I feel a sharp pain in my chest, which makes me sweat. The thread is flickering. Why is that? I touch it, and yes, it's physical in nature. I need to figure this out. I am more confident with this thread now because I figure I am the only one who can see it. I walk more confidently, but I still feel like a puppet whenever it appears. When people look at me, I think they are about to ask me what's that on my chest. So, I walk mostly with my head down to avoid any eye contact. Eye contact is kind of an invitation for any stranger to ask any question if they want. Or they can just smile and nod, and you have to nod back; otherwise, it's disrespectful. But right now, I feel confident. I walk with my head up, with a flickering, shimmering thread attached to my heart. Anuj calls me to say that we will talk at night, and in the meantime, I should visit the waterfall. He gives me the directions. We will meet at night. I have to attend to the guests. It's good to have some alone time to think about our fate, Megha. Although I really want to stay here to talk to the blue-eyed foreigner.

I put my cigarette in the ashtray and skip towards my room. I jump on my bed, unzip my bag, and pull out a pair of pants and a t-shirt. I switch on the geyser, arrange my clothes on the edge of the bed, and turn the tap. I begin to wash myself. I am having an erection as I think of this blue-eyed foreigner, I also think about Megha and the waterfall. I need to decide our fate, and this foreigner is interfering with my rational thinking. What if I decide to leave you for this young foreigner. I need to think rationally so I decide to work on myself. Thinking about the foreigner, her lips, her squeezed together breasts, her green veins all over her fair body, her teeth. The imagination is so vivid that I start questioning the attention of my brain for different things. I'm about to cum when I think of Megha, and my heart skips a beat, and the shimmering thread appears, red-hot and glowing like a heater rod. I touch it, and it burns my skin a bit. It's absurd that the imaginary motif is burning

me in reality. Is this burned mark also an illusion? I get out of the shower, feeling good and fulfilled. I wipe my body, fit myself into my clothes, and comb my hair. I decide to leave without telling Anuj because I don't want to climb the stairs. After walking down and climbing up the steep roads, disregarding all the collection-worthy Buddhist products and reminiscing about all the beautiful girls I encountered along the way, I finally reach the waterfall. It has been a tiring journey, but the spot is simply the best. On my way, I pick up a pack of Marlboro Light and find myself breathing heavily. Suddenly, an image of the blue-eyed girl enters my mind. Her body seems to be from another world entirely. I recall her fair skin with a light red blush adorning her cheeks. She is incredibly attractive, radiating good health. Oh God, she has taken complete control of my thoughts. I look for a big rock where I can sit undisturbed. I see people doing stupid stuff like dipping their face in the puddle of the waterfall and clicking pictures of themselves meditating on a rock near the flow of water. Finally, I found the rock I needed. It's perfect, flat, with dry hays planted around, so the fear of seeing a snake is out of the question. The only problem is the bush behind me. What if a mountain lion hides in there and attacks me when I am least alert? I don't want to die thinking about a girl. It would be shameful for my belief system. I want to die in awareness, observing every sensation and sound—the movement of trees, the crawling of ants, the slow-moving clouds, grasping all the harmony of this magnificent existence. And I hope the day I die, it should not rain, otherwise, every magnificent phenomenon of nature will have the constant rain sound, which will be boring, and that will be the only chance I am going to get. So, good God, if you are there, please don't let it rain when I die. A wooden stick creaks, and my fearful heart alerts me. I look back and see a poor guy looking for a place to pee. Phew. I lie down on the rock, looking up at the sky. The voice of the waterfall is so loud that it helps me concentrate. Oh Megha, do I really want you in my life? The shimmering thread appears, and I wriggle it a bit. I like this tingling feeling in my heart; it just boosts my mood. As I wriggle it, trying to find the last point of it, I see two Buddhist monks sitting on the edge of a mountain top wearing maroon shawls sharing a cold drink with each other. One gulps a few times, stares into the sky, and sighs, then passes it on without looking at the other. The process is repeated until the bottle is empty, as the monk seated on the right empties the bottle. He sighs.

What could have in their life that they decide to drink coke and sigh? Maybe that's the way of a non-smoker. They gulp and sigh as they curse their life. But they are monks. They are supposed to be joyful, and why on earth is a cold drink allowed in the life of a celibate monk? They have consciously dropped all capitalist pleasures to find inner pleasure. But what is this? I feel cheated, and I don't even know them. Oh, this stupid mind just wanders everywhere. I want it to focus on Megha, but it wanders. Maybe because two monks gulping a cold drink as they burp and sigh is a new image for my mind. I forgive you. Now let's think of Megha rationally. First question, do I love her? Well, I love everyone, but I don't want them to start stupid conversations with me. I love everyone unconditionally though. So do I want her in my life? Do I really need someone to depend on? I don't think so. Well, what about sexual relationships? Is sex a good enough reason to be with a girl? No, I don't think so. But I like her, that much I know. Then what's the problem? Well, that is the right question to ask. Let's assume I like her, love her completely. Then what's the problem? Why is my subconscious looking for ways to avoid her? Let me think about problems. First, I have to stay good for her. I need to trim my beard and get a haircut. I need to shave down there every week. I have to pick up her phone instantly. I need to make her happy, remember her birthday and other important dates. I have to be aware of her periods. I hope I don't get angry with her. I have to explore new sexual techniques to keep the relationship brisk. I don't know if I am any good. Will I be able to give her the pleasure she imagined? What if she is having a bad day and she calls me to cry it out, and I am writing? I am not good at providing emotional support. I look at life situations as a dramatic movie scene. I feel a weight off. The shimmering thread is flickering. Is it going to vanish? So what should I do, as they say, a leap of faith? Everything will fall where it needs to be. She sounded so supportive in the texts. As Stephen King said, writing is a lonely job. It helps if one has some support, and her wife is his support. He was writing his first novel *Carrie*, and after writing it and thinking of it

as a worthless manuscript, he dumped it into the dustbin. His wife then picked it up, read it, and forced him to rewrite the manuscript and publish it. And rest is history. Megha is a cute girl, she is intelligent, she reads books, and she is the perfect person to test my manuscript and all the good sex. She seems like the type of girl who is homely and submissive. I turn on my side to hide my erection. No, sex is not the reason to be with a girl. I want to be with her, but I don't want to have sex with her. Well, I blame God. He created us, men and women, and now we only think about each other. Nice one, God. Nice one. And to be sure of it, he gave us sexual desire. And I am just rejecting his ideas. I am scared that the love I am feeling towards a girl will fade away as soon as I make love with her. I always imagine the situation that I am lying naked on the bed with my eyes wide open. She is sleeping, resting her head on my shoulder, and her small arm caressing me. Her bare breasts are pressing against me, and her leg is bent from her knee, which rests on my groin area. And I am feeling disgust towards myself and towards God. That the woman I thought I love was just a trick of my mind. Now that I have had sex with her, the feeling went away, and I am thinking what to do with her. I begin with ignoring her calls. We fight for no reason. We eat. We celebrate. And we fuck even more. But I am thinking of ways to break up. I feel disgust. I wake up with a jerk. When did I fall asleep? I look back at the bush. No mountain lion. I get up and look around. A few people are there. I hurry toward the hotel. The clouds are roaring hard. It's going to rain heavily. I should hurry. Early drops of rain are falling on my forehead. The drops are chilly and cold. As soon as I enter the hotel, heavy rain emerges as if waiting for me to enter the premises. I enter my little corridor, hoping to see the blue-eyed beauty, but I feel sadness for not finding her there. I unlock my door. Anuj is sitting on my bed in thoughts with a dull face. He looks at me and attempts a smile. Almost there. That's it. He smiles at me and shows me a bottle of cheap rum. Maybe it is what he can do. Anyway, I smile back. I think of asking if he is going to sleep here with me. If yes then I need to tell him not today. I need to finalize my conclusion about Megha. I settle down on the bed as he pulls out two glasses. He pours sixty ml of drink into each glass, and we talk as we clink our glasses. His face tells me that he drinks to escape reality. The amount of joy and fulfillment on his face reveals the amount of suffering he's in, and it's bone-chilling. Despite feeling the urge to ask about his problems and blunders, I don't have the nerve to do so. "So, what's the deal here? What's happened to you? You always seem so different and dull," I ask him with utter sincerity. His lips flinch, and tears flow from his eyes as he sips his drink. He asks me for a cigarette as he cries. I remember that I bought some on the way and gave him one while lighting one for myself. He takes a drag, wipes his tears, and then mutters. "I am worthless, a stain on my bloodline. I left my job to live life, the way I wanted to live, but it's terrible here. Freedom means being your own boss, and if anyone is above you, they're going to contain you. In the beginning, it was good. My boss and the owner of this place used to sit as a host, but slowly the transition was made, and somehow, I ended up working full time. How stupid am I? I left my job for another job. Does it make sense to you?"

Oh, a question for me. I take a gulp of my drink and drag a puff. Yes, it makes sense. We have to go back, right? It's your conditioning, right? Your whole life, you've been trained by your parents and teachers that a job is what everyone should do; that's the purpose of life. That's understandable; your illusions are shattering, and you will get there and you didn't tell me the problem you're facing yet. "Oh, I thought I told you just now." "That was just the surface. Tell me your desires." "My desire? I want to travel." "Wait a minute. Think truthfully. Rationally. Then tell me your desires." "Okay," he says as he sits staring at the distance. It's pouring outside with the uneven murmuring of the clouds. The balcony seems dark. The rain is really pouring heavily. It's hard on my ears. It feels like the rain wants me to hear it. "I hear you. To the point, it is making me uncomfortable. Does it represent Megha? She also wants to be heard, and that is also making me uncomfortable. It's unusual for both to try to get validation from anyone else. Both are beautiful in their own way. They should own it." "Maybe that's what it means to be vulnerable. Hmm, I am very vulnerable when I am writing. I share lots of deep desires and weird fantasies for thousands of people to read. Oh, Megha, why do you find me interesting? Is there something about my face that you like? Because that's the only visible part I

carry with me. Or are my hips good? I have good hips. But not attractive enough to fall in love with me. What could it be?" "Or do you like to read, and you see me as a future writer, and you want to be with me just as an experiment on how a writer finds his way to lakhs of people? Is it enough to fall in love with someone? What if in my mid-journey, I start to teach literature and stop writing by then? Will you love me then, Megha? I don't think so. I tell you, Megha, that's a possibility. I am going to write a few novels, but the legendary ones. I feel a sharp pain in my chest. My shimmering thread is pulling hard as if on the other end someone is tugging it. I somehow see in my mind that Megha is screaming in her room, pulling the thread. Her face is blood red. She pulls hard, and a wave shoots out in the thread, affecting me. I fall on my knees hard. The pain is so sharp. I'm on the floor, waiting for the experience to go away. I fold my legs lying on the floor as my knees touch my chest, I chug my drink in one go. I squint my eyes shut, feeling pain all over my body. I see her in my mind, and the imagery is vivid. She is naked now, ceremonially swaying hard on her bed, sitting on her knees. She has the shimmering thread in her hand, which is also connected to her heart. She's moving it in circles above her head.

I'm still in excruciating pain, and the scene in my mind is becoming even more terrifying. She screams with crazy eyes, and her nipples are erect out of sheer anger. Her body is patchy red on her bronzed fair skin. I can see her subtle body following her physical body, and it frightens me deeply. Her scream makes my heart vibrate and my body jerk in pain as if I'm possessed, like a witch hiding in her cave, pinning my puppet with sharp gold needles. The fear of dying consumes me, and I desperately want to open my eyes, but I can't. I feel utterly powerless and unable to control anything. I focus on her hair, which is brushing against her body as she moves, making her appear even more unhinged. Something in her eyes tells me that she is not what she seems; there's pain and hatred, and she no longer believes in any kind of love. It's as if all the animosity directed towards me is turning her into a demon. I'm still experiencing this from my point of view, and I dread her looking at me and running towards me to harm me. As she continues to scream, the shimmering thread turns blood red, and the room fills with the eerie color. Her eyes become even crazier and blood-red, wide with intensity. She holds a crazy angry face. I can see the evil in her aura. Her eyes dart at me. I'm feeling terrified, and I can't control my bodily functions. She screams and hauls toward me. leaping from her bed, her breasts weirdly jerks. She hauls towards me, grabs me, and screams in my ears. I sense my soul leaving my petrified body. I try to run, but my body jerks hard, and my eyes are wide open as I find myself in her grip, my body is in shock and unresponsive. Suddenly, my soul returns to my body, and I find myself sitting on the bed with Anuj. I look around and pull out my wallet, glancing inside to find a thousand rupees. I sigh and put it back where it belongs. "The truth is," Anuj says, "I don't really like traveling. Or should I say, the uncertain part of it. I want it to be like this – a job that pleases my creativity, I need a girl whom I can fuck. I need a few friends I can drink with. He points his glass towards me. Now and then we go traveling to different places. I make vlogs, and we eat food. At night I fuck my girl and then we drink and smoke and life will be good."

Contempt fills me as I listen to him. I feel sad for him and his miserable life, which seems destined to remain miserable. Drunk and unable to control my words, I take a deep breath and I say to him, "What do you mean you fuck your girl? Is that all a girl's purpose in your life? Just to be used for sex?" "Well, doesn't she want that too?" he responds. "Not the way you explained it. Does your worth lie only in your genitals?" I counter. "No, of course not," he says. "How can you reduce women to just objects for your pleasure? Don't you see them as human beings with feelings? How can you include sex as part of your routine? Will she always be available for you whenever you want?" I challenge him. "I'm sorry, if somehow I hurt your feelings, but I don't take women seriously. My ex broke my heart, and it changed me somehow. I don't look at women the way I used to. I only see things I can use; the rest is just a long-lost scream that I don't care about," he explains. I gulp down my drink, feeling a mix of emotions. Some people seem to deserve their misery, and he is one of them. I hope he will get better, that something will change him. I hope he learns not to be the source of anyone's suffering, as

he knows what it feels like to be hurt and should not seek revenge. His violent nature scares me. How can a human, capable of questioning their existence, resort to animalistic instincts to deal with life's situations? The rain has stopped, and we have emptied the cheap rum. I suggested we should go to the balcony, and there, we lit a cigarette and share it. Thoughts of pushing him down from the balcony crosses my mind. How many people will he hurt? I don't know, but I could potentially save them. All it would take is a push. I've seen his sociopathic nature in the past – staring into nothingness with a grin on his face, eyes moving like a lion about to hunt. I've witnessed him drink two full bottles of cheap rum and sit there as if nothing happened, calm and composed, I wonder what would happen if more bad experiences turned Anuj into a complete sociopath. Parallel to us, there is a hotel, and a married couple walks out. They light a cigarette, the woman holding the grill while the man embraces her from behind, sharing the cigarette with her. They drink tea from the same steel glass. Our eyes meet, and I greet them with a nod, but they don't nod back. I sense a hostile vibe in their body language. The girl is beautiful, the kind you might marry. Her big eyes, blond hair with dark brown patches, and a green Himachali kurti caught my attention. I had considered buying a similar one on the way but dismissed the idea. She wears tight blue trousers that accentuate her figure, and I notice that she has larger than average breasts. As we smoke and drink, I occasionally glance at my watch. The sound of low-toned music fills the air, and I inquire about it from Anuj. He points to a nearby cafe where a live night is taking place. I express my desire to go there, and Anuj agrees, adding that we need money to enter. I assure him that it's not a problem. Feeling more confident and a bit drunk, I make a bold gesture toward the married woman standing with her husband. I nod looking at her, earning a smirk from her and a glare from her husband. We leave the hotel, the ground outside is wet and slippery from the rain, but we manage to reach the cafe. It's spacious and calm, with many foreigners smoking and drinking. Large Himalayan rocks in their raw form adorn the front, and various plants decorate the edges of the wooden flooring. We have to take off our shoes to enter the sitting area. A local band sings Bollywood love song remix, their drunk performance is surprisingly enjoyable. We settle at a corner table a few feet away from the band. As the music is loud, a man with thinning hair approaches and I ask him for an ashtray. He seems disappointed, and I tell him to come back in ten minutes. When he returns with the ashtray, we smoke a few cigarettes. Feeling intoxicated, I look at the liquor options and order two Bacardi dark rums, 30ml two pegs each, and two chocolate brownies to elevate our tipsy state. It's an odd combination, and I can see the serving guy's confusion on his face. Anuj nudges me and points out a girl sitting alone across from us, next to the band. He mentions that she has been staring at him for quite some time. As I sip my rum and take a bite of the chocolate brownie, I glance at her. She's wearing a white men's jacket and a red t-shirt underneath, and her large breasts are noticeable even from a distance.

She has a boxy face, and her hair seems wet. Her eyes are a little wet too. Her smile is cute and apologetic. The performing group stops for a five-minute break, and she moves out with them. I finish my drink and start to enjoy my brownie bit by bit, dissolving it in my mouth. The chocolate touches every corner of my mouth. It feels good, and I get high with every bite of my brownie. The performing band returns, and so does she. The singer is different this time. The girl has a beer with her. she wipes her lips before taking a gulp and sensually makes a pout looking at the top of the beer. Then she looks at me. I'm looking at her, and she takes another sip, looking at me. I lower my eyes; I'm a little shy. I elbowed Anuj and told him that she's looking at me. "No, she's looking at me," he says. "No, she's looking at me, bro," I insist. I look at her again, and she looks at me again. We stare for a while, my heart is pounding in my chest. I check for the shimmering thread, but it's not there. I break eye contact again. I curse my parents for producing such an under-confident kid. "I will not look away. She has to lower down her eyes before me; I am a man. Why am I shying away?" I think to myself. I look at her again, and she looks at me again. I am staring, I am uncomfortable, and my eyes start to tear up. She seems to be doing it effortlessly. She nods at me and smiles. My heart skips a beat. I hit Anuj to tell him, "Dude, she is gesturing me to come to her." "Bullshit! He tells me. "I am serious!" I say. "You are drunk," he

replies. "She will slap you hard." My heart is pounding, but I decide to go to her, a slap is worthy enough to try, I am not going to say anything bad. If she slaps me, it's okay. Anyway, no one knows me here. I get up with the brownie plate in my right hand and a cigarette in my left hand. My whole being is trembling, but the drunk me is confident to approach her. I go to her, and I see Anuj following me. She is so comfortable that she gestures for me to sit beside her. I am wowed; such an effortless thing to do. Anuj sits on a parallel bench before the table, turns toward the band, with half his attention on the girl sitting beside me. I am trying to act casual. We lock eyes, and she smiles—such a beautiful smile. I smile back. My instinct tells me that I should talk, so I reach for her ears and ask if she wants to drink something. "Whatever you want. I am okay," she replies. "Cool," I say. She starts swaying to the song, but it feels like she's trying to impress me. Somehow, she is filling me with positive energy. She locks her arm with mine, and we sway together. She comes closer to me; her body is attached to mine as if we are sharing a similar soul. It feels warm; I sense an intimacy that excites me. She looks at me, and I look back at her. We lock eyes again, and it feels like she's giving me the "blowjob eyes. I'm getting an erection, so I look at my brownie. Am I delusional? Am I assuming that Megha is trying hard for my attention and now she's giving me the "blowjob eyes"? I'm going to remember these eyes for the foreseeable future. I might use them in my novel. Oh god. The server comes with the drink; it's the same brand, dark rum. 60ml each for 900 rupees. The guy and I lock eyes, and he's trying to tell me something. His face looks eerie, but I can't figure out what he means. I can't have an erection and a drink at the same time. I let my guard down; I don't want to think anymore. I look back at her, and she looks deep into my eyes. I lean forward, and she follows. We kiss, and it happens for a while, but it feels casual. Anuj looks at me, and we communicate with minor expressions and gestures. She tightens her grip, and she seems drunk; her eyes are heavy. She radiates warmth, and I finish my drink. She asks me where I'm staying, and I feel a rush in my body. I tell her, and she asks if she can chill with me for a while, as it's still 8 PM. "It's my lucky day. I'm going to have sex after six months," I think to myself. The idea excites me, and my thing is out of control, throbbing. I adjust it to hide it. I pay the bill, and she waits outside, looking at her phone, fixing her hair. My mind starts to imagine the ways I'm going to work on her. We walk hand in hand; we're not talking as much. Is it normal? Is she using me today? All she wants is my thing, not the talking bullshit. Anyway, I lift the flight mode off my phone. I'm not scared anymore about finding messages from anyone. There's no message from Megha, which is both a relief and disappointment. I text Anuj just to be sure he's gone to sleep where he's supposed to be. He replies with a thumbs-up. We enter the room, and she jumps on the bed, asking me for a cigarette. I light two of them and give her one. She smokes sensually, inviting me, opening her beautiful thighs. I feel uncomfortable, something is wrong. I shut myself up, telling myself that I have a tendency of ruining beautiful moments and relationships with suspicions and being intellectual. I tell her I don't have any condoms on me. She tells me not to worry; she has one. "Well, too good to be true," I think. "Oh my god, just shut up." She starts to undress, and she asks me to switch off the light. I tell her I want to see. Seeing her large breasts dangling with her minor movements, my animal nature takes over me, but I'm a conscious man, and I observe. So, I stay composed, though my body is shaking. She removes her tight-fitted jeans, followed by her dark green panties. They roll down her fair thighs. I thought of feeling them, but I feel disgust, so I don't. She covers herself with the blanket and gestures for me to come in with her. Holding a smile, I remove my clothes. The winter cold chill gives me goosebumps, so I snuggle in with her and turn her on her side. I push my thing against her tail, and she moans as I grab her large breasts. I'm about to come, so I stop and kiss her body. I'm inside her, and it's very warm. The blanket feels as if a heater is hidden somewhere in it. I move up and down a few times, and she starts to fake it. I can sense the fakeness. Why does she have to fake it? I wonder. I am losing my erection. I grab her breast hard, and the blood instantly flows through my thing. It is live again. Something alerts me, and I think of Megha. The shimmering thread appears – it's hot red. I grab it with my right hand. The shimmering thread burns my hand, but I don't let go. Steam is coming out of my hand, and I'm in pain. The woman before me turns into Megha, and I start to work on her. I sense love to the fullest.

Every pleasure she feels uplifts my pleasure. My pleasure is dependent on her pleasure. The more Megha is into it, the more she moans, and the more aroused I become. It feels like I'm capable of something. I can make her feel all this. She has rather small breasts, but they're good enough to get me heavily aroused. As I'm thrusting into her, I try to kiss her, but the taste of rum snaps me out of my imagination. The bar girl is there, fully aroused. What magic have I done on her? I feel contempt toward myself. It feels like I am cheating Megha by being with the bar girl. What if I try to have sex with other girls when I'm in a relationship with Megha? Now, I lost interest in this naked cafe girl. I turn her and pull my thing out. It is pulsating. I hold her tight, and tears come out of my eyes. I betrayed Megha and her trust. I don't deserve her. I try to control my emotions. I close my eyes and try to sleep in the warmth of the cafe girl. A few minutes pass, and the cafe girl's hand shuffles in the blanket. She touches the tip of my penis and asks, "You didn't cum?" "No," I say. "Are you done?" she asks. "I think so," I reply. She starts to work on herself. She moves slowly, holding my thing with her right hand while using her left to pleasure herself. In the mindset of shuffling her body in the blanket, she starts to rub my thing. She jerks sensually as she's about to cum. It feels good to see a girl masturbating in the same blanket. It feels like she decide to cum on my blanket, and I am also edging towards it, so I grab her hand and ask her not to cum on my bedsheet. She pauses and pats my thing. She grabs her head and sighs. Then she removes the blanket, and the warmth turns to steam in the air. Bone-chilling cold enters my body. I am losing heat. "What are you doing?" I ask her. "I need to go now," she says as she starts to dress. "Well, can't you stay here for the night? We can cuddle, and we can talk about stuff, you know. We haven't talked much since we met," I suggest. "I charge five thousand for the full night," she says. I feel uneasy, knowing what she meant. I pretend that I always knew, then I ask how much for an hour. She tells me a thousand rupees, her eyes widening. I feel amazing that I fooled her about knowing she was a prostitute. Every piece of the puzzle connected in time. When Anuj said to me that she was looking at him, and we fought over it, she would have gone with him if he was able to approach her first. And the eerie look on the face of the serving guy. He was warning me against her. Maybe he knew about her deeds. I ask for her name. She says, "Ruchika." "Nice to meet you, Ruchika," I say. She is done wearing her clothes. She rubs her hand on her stomach to flatten the creases and tells me that she has met many men, but I am the biggest loser of them all. She calls me an asshole. I pull out my wallet and give her the only thousand rupees note I have, as she doesn't take online payment. I had to give it to her. I don't want to wake Anuj because he will make fun of me. So, I give it to her, risking my reality check if I am dreaming or not. "How am I an asshole?" I ask. "Fuck off!" she shouts as she leaves. I fall asleep, thinking, "What the fuck just happened?" I see myself running, panting, and sweating. My friends are meeting me as I run. After a while, I see Megha with her arms wide open, smiling at me. I am running towards her, and she is few feet away. As soon as I reach her, her breasts start to release milk, and her t-shirt becomes wet. Instead of hugging her, I dodge her and push her into the nearby bush. I see her crying as I run past her. Darkness is ahead of me, but I don't stop; I embrace it and get lost. I wake up abruptly. My shimmering thread is flickering. It's unusually fat and pulsating. I sit idle, checking my phone; it's 11:30 pm. I think of this weird dream. Somehow, I know that Megha is the most perfect girl I have ever seen, and I am not going to find someone like her. But I am a demon who will possess her and hurt her knowingly or unknowingly because that's what demons do. I am a socially detached person. I play with emotions; I control them, they don't control me. I look at my phone, then open Instagram and look at her photo. I smile. I tap on the three dots and block her on Instagram. Then I open WhatsApp and block her there too. Then I block her mobile number. Tears come out of my eyes. My thread vanishes for good. I feel lighter. I go to the balcony and light myself a cigarette. I think of Angela, the blue-eyed beauty. Anuj told me her name when we were talking. After a while, Angela walks out from the right balcony. She lights her cigarette, and I nod at her. She nods back, and her smile stirs my heart. She speaks her first words to me. "Isn't it amazing that it's snowing in March in Himachal? Do you want to play with the snow?" I look around, and indeed, the whole area is covered in snow. I asked her when it happened. "In the past two hours. So, do you want to come down

and play?" I pull out my wallet and open it slowly. I find nothing, and my heart skips a beat. "If it's a dream, I like it," I agree with her. She tells me that her friends are going to join her shortly. It seems like she wants to feel safe. We met outside in the small corridor. We don't talk much, and we walk silently. I ask her where she is from, and she tells me that she is from England but living in France. We go outside, and she stops back, and I walk a few steps away to start making my snowball. A snowball hits my back, and she laughs. It feels like I've known her for ages; she's really amazing. I throw my snowball, and it almost hits her thighs.

She throws one snowball again, but it misses. Then, she receives a call, a few of her friends are joining her. I throw another snowball, and it almost touches her arm but misses. "Hey, that's cheating. I was talking on my phone," she says. "I am sorry," I reply, and I throw another snowball, which hits her stomach. "I am sorry," I say, running toward her. "Are you hurt? I am so sorry." "I am fine the jacket saved me". "I am really sorry". I told her to hit me to make it even. "Don't talk rubbish. I am fine. Let's stop, we are acting childish," she says, and I agree. Her friends join us, and they ask what happened. She says, "Nothing, we were just having fun." They decide to go and see the night life of cafes. She asks me to join them, and it's tempting, but I decline. I need to sleep, and if I am sleeping, I need to wake up. She gives me a friendly grin, and then they all leave. I watch them go, and I sigh.